



**COMBINED MANUAL
DESCRIPTION OF CHANGES ATTACHMENT
REVISED SECTIONS – ISSUED 01/2026**

DRAFT

PROPOSED CHANGES

The EFFECTIVE DATE of the changes is the same as the issuance date unless stated otherwise.

0018.18 (Earned Income Disregards) in MSA updates the Student Earned Income Disregard to correspond with 01/26 COLA changes.

0020.21 (MSA Assistance Standards) in MSA updates the MSA Assistance Standards to correspond with 01/26 COLA changes.

0020.24 (Personal Needs Allowance) in MSA, GA, GRH updates the personal needs allowance to correspond with 01/26 COLA changes.

0023.21 (Representative Payee Services) in MSA, updates COLA changes to SSA maximum rep payee fees.

0029.06.03 (Supplemental Security Income Program) updates SSI benefit rates to correspond with 01/26 COLA changes.

EARNED INCOME DISREGARDS

0018.18

Earned income disregards are an employment incentive. Subtract earned income disregards only from the monthly earned income of a client. See [0017.12.06 \(Earned Income\)](#), [0017.15.33 \(Self-Employment Income\)](#). Do not reduce earned income to less than \$0 or use earned income disregards to reduce unearned income.

People may lose the earned income disregard when computing overpayments for failure to report a change timely. See [0025.03 \(Determining Incorrect Payment Amounts\)](#).

MFIP, DWP, GA:

Disregard the 1st \$65 of earned income per wage earner plus half of the remaining earned income of the assistance unit.

SNAP:

Allow 20% of the unit's gross earned income as an earned income deduction. See [0017.15.36.06 \(Identifying Title IV or Federal Student Aid\)](#), [0017.15.36.09 \(Student Financial Aid Deductions\)](#).

If after applying the farm loss offset, the unit passes the GIT and income remains, allow a 20% deduction of the gross earned income from that amount prior to applying other deductions. See the [Self-Employment Guide \(PDF\)](#).

MSA:

For SSI recipients, no county action is required.

For non-SSI recipients due to excess income, disregard the 1st \$65 of earned income plus half of the remaining earned income of the assistance unit.

- Allow the Student Earned Income Disregard from earned income when a client meets ALL 3 of the following conditions:
 - Is under age 22.
 - Is certified as blind or disabled by the Social Security Administration or the State Medical Review Team.
 - Is expecting to attend school at least 1 month in the next calendar quarter, or did attend school at least 1 month of the current calendar quarter.

Limit the Student Earned Income Disregard to a maximum of **\$2,410** a month and **\$9,730** in a calendar year. Apply it only to the client's income.

Also see [0018.06 \(Work Expense Deductions\)](#).

GRH:

For aged, blind or disabled adults, follow MSA.

For all other adults, follow GA.

MFIP, DWP, SNAP, GA, GRH:

No provisions.

MSA:

MSA has assistance standards whose use depends upon the applicant or participant's circumstances including:

- The SSI Federal Benefit Rate (FBR) upon which the client's SSI grant is based. See [0029.06.03 \(Supplemental Security Income Program\)](#).
- Whether a person is eligible for a home and community-based services (HCBS) waiver, including:
 - Community Access for Disability Inclusion (CADI).
 - Elderly Waiver (EW).
 - Brain Injury (BI).
 - Community Alternative Care for Chronically Ill Individuals (CAC).
 - Developmental Disabilities (DD).

See the [Minnesota Health Care Programs Eligibility Policy Manual](#) for information on these programs. A person who is eligible for any HCBS waiver is considered to be living alone.

- Whether a person meets county plan requirements for Housing Support placement (GRH plan) though not actually living in a Housing Support setting.
- Whether a person is eligible for MSA Housing Assistance. See [0023.24 \(MSA Housing Assistance\)](#). A person who is eligible for MSA Housing Assistance is always considered to be living alone. Apply the "living alone" assistance standard when determining eligibility.
- A client's marital status.
- A client's living arrangement.

Apply the living alone assistance standard if a person lives in their own residence without others.

If a person lives with others, apply the living with others assistance standard UNLESS they:

- Are eligible for an HCBS waiver.

OR

- Meet county plan requirements for Housing Support placement.

OR

- Are eligible for MSA Housing Assistance.

If a person does not meet one of the criteria above, determine whether they constitute a separate household from others who reside at that address. A separate household exists when a person:

- Is subject to an individual written lease or rental agreement.

AND

- Purchases, prepares, and eats meals separately from others in the household.

AND

- Has exclusive use of part of the residence (such as a bedroom).

A person who lives with others may or may not be receiving a reduced SSI benefit due to receiving In-kind Support and Maintenance (ISM).

A person who lives with others and receives a reduced amount of SSI based on Federal Living Arrangement B cannot be considered a separate household.

MSA COMMUNITY STANDARDS

The standard for MSA applicants and participants who live independently in the community is the total of the client's MSA assistance standard and any ongoing special needs allowances. See [0023 \(Special Needs Payments\)](#). If a married couple lives together and both partners are applying and have an MSA basis of eligibility, combine their incomes to determine eligibility and benefit level. Use the highest appropriate standard.

A county may set its own standards at a higher level than the State Standards, but there is no State aid for the extra costs.

2026 MSA MONTHLY ASSISTANCE STANDARDS

Person living alone	\$1,055.00
Person living with others	\$755.33
Married couple living alone	\$1,582.00
Married couple living with others	\$1,058.00
Married couple living alone (pre-1994)	\$1,597.00
Married couple living with others (pre-1994).	\$1,321.00

APPLY THE LIVING ALONE STANDARD WHEN:

- A single person receives SSI with Federal Living Arrangement A and lives alone.
- A single person does NOT receive SSI solely due to excess income and lives alone.
- A single person lives with others, receives SSI with Federal Living Arrangement A, and is eligible for MA waivers, a GRH plan, MSA Housing Assistance, or is a separate household from others residing at that address.
- A single person lives with others, receives SSI with Federal Living Arrangement B, and is eligible for MA waivers, a GRH plan, or MSA Housing Assistance.
- A single person receives SSI with Federal Living Arrangement A due to a presidential disaster declaration and/or being homeless.
- A married person lives with his or her ineligible spouse and receives SSI with Federal Living Arrangement A or does not receive SSI due to excess income.
- A married person lives with an ineligible spouse and receives SSI with Federal Living Arrangement B and is eligible for MA Waivers, a GRH plan, or a shelter special need.

APPLY THE LIVING WITH OTHERS STANDARD WHEN:

- A person receives SSI with Federal Living Arrangement B, and is not eligible for MA waivers, a GRH plan, or MSA Housing Assistance.
- A person does NOT receive SSI solely due to excess income, and lives with others (including minor children but excluding spouse), and is NOT eligible for MA waivers, a GRH plan, or MSA Housing Assistance.
- A person receives SSI with Federal Living Arrangement A and lives with others (including minor children). Do not apply this standard to a person living only with a spouse ineligible for MSA (see "Apply the living alone standard when:" above.)
- A married person lives with his or her ineligible spouse and receives SSI with Federal Living Arrangement B, and is NOT eligible for MA waivers, a GRH plan, or MSA Housing Assistance.

APPLY THE MARRIED COUPLE LIVING ALONE STANDARD WHEN:

- A couple receives SSI with Federal Living Arrangement A or is ineligible for SSI solely due to excess income and lives alone.
- A couple receives SSI with Federal Living Arrangement A or is ineligible for SSI solely due to excess income, lives with others, and one or both is eligible for MA Waivers, a GRH plan, or MSA Housing Assistance.
- A couple receives SSI with Federal Living Arrangement A due to presidential disaster declaration and/or being homeless.

APPLY THE MARRIED COUPLE LIVING WITH OTHERS STANDARD WHEN:

- A couple lives with others and receives SSI with Federal Living Arrangement B or is ineligible for SSI solely due to excess income.
- A couple receives SSI with Federal Living Arrangement A, lives with others, and are NOT eligible for MA Waivers, a GRH plan, or MSA Housing Assistance.

MSA FACILITIES STANDARD:

The assistance standard for people at the SSI \$30 FBR (Federal Living Arrangement "D") and living in facilities where personal needs are not otherwise provided, OR some children who are blind, is the personal needs allowance. See [0020.24 \(Personal Needs Allowance\)](#).

A person hospitalized for illness may continue to receive their community standard established before being hospitalized if it is more than the personal needs allowance and if the person meets the conditions of temporary absence in [0014.09 \(Assistance Units - Temporary Absence\)](#).

MSA clients who are residents of a licensed residential facility are NOT eligible for any special needs allowances EXCEPT for representative payee services. See [0023.21 \(Representative Payee Services\)](#).

NOTE: Clients in a Minnesota Consolidated Chemical Dependency Treatment Fund (CCDTF) facility are NOT eligible for MSA.

MFIP, SNAP:

No provisions.

DWP:

An allowance of up to \$70 per month per DWP unit member to pay for expenses such as household products and personal products. See [0022.12 \(How to Calc. Benefit Level - MFIP/DWP/GA\)](#).

MSA:

The personal needs allowance is **\$132**. Consider this allowance as the standard of need for MSA clients who meet 1 of the criteria listed below. Also see [0020.21 \(MSA Assistance Standards\)](#).

- Clients in medical facilities where MA pays the cost of care.
- SSI recipients who receive the \$30 Federal Benefit Rate for federal living arrangement D, see [0029.06.03 \(Supplemental Security Income Program\)](#).
- Blind children who meet all the following requirements:
 - They live with their parents and would be ineligible for SSI or their SSI would be less if their parents' income or assets were counted.
AND
 - They previously received a personal needs allowance from SSI when they were in a Title XIX (Medicaid) facility.
AND
 - They receive MA under 1 of the following programs: TEFRA Option, Developmental Disabilities (DD) Waiver, Community Alternative Care (CAC), Community Access for Disability Inclusion (CADI), or Traumatic Brain Injury (TBI).
See the [Minnesota Health Care Programs Eligibility Policy Manual](#) for information on these programs.

GA:

The personal needs allowance is **\$132** for clients in licensed residential facilities provided this need is not otherwise met. See [0014.03.03 \(Determining the Cash Assistance Unit\)](#).

GRH:

The personal needs allowance is **\$132**. Allow the **\$132** as a deduction from net income before calculating the GRH payment. For clients who have insufficient income, it may be paid from GA.

MFIP, DWP, SNAP, GA:

No provisions.

MSA:

MSA allows a recurring special need payment for professional representative payee services. Clients must provide a statement from the organization that SSA has authorized it to collect a fee for representative payee services. Clients must verify the authorization at application and whenever there is a change in representative payee.

This special need payment is allowed regardless of the participant's living arrangement.

Annually, SSA establishes the maximum monthly fee that can be charged for professional representative payee services. For 2026, the maximum is \$57. This amount is allowed as an MSA special need allowance.

SSA allows a higher representative payee fee for recipients who have drug or alcohol addiction. For 2026, that maximum is \$106. This higher amount is not allowed as an MSA special need allowance.

GRH:

No provisions. For when to allow income deductions for representative payee services, see [0018.39 \(Prior and Other Income Reductions\)](#).

The Social Security Administration operates the Supplemental Security Income (SSI) program. This program provides monthly income to low income aged, blind, and disabled people. GA and RCA applicants who are aged, blind, or disabled must apply for SSI. MFIP participants who are disabled must apply for SSI. See [0012.12 \(Applying for Other Benefits\)](#), [0012.12.06 \(Special Services – Applying for Social Security\)](#), [0030.03 \(Refugee Cash Assistance\)](#). SSI recipients may be eligible for MSA.

All SSI recipients have a basis of eligibility for MA but are not automatically eligible for benefits. SSI recipients who are age 18 or over or under age 18 and blind have a basis of eligibility for MSA. SSI recipients are not eligible for DWP, MFIP or GA. See [0013 \(Basis of Eligibility\)](#).

SSI RESOURCE LIMITS

Individual \$2,000

Couple \$3,000

SSI FEDERAL BENEFIT RATES 2026

	Individual	Couple
Federal Living Arrangement (FLA) A(Own home)	\$994.00	\$1,491.00
Federal Living Arrangement (FLA) B (Home of another)	\$662.67	\$994.00
Federal Living Arrangement (FLA) D (Living in medical facility)	\$30.00	

GA, GRH and RCA applicants who are age 65 or older, blind, or disabled must apply for SSI unless they have good cause. MFIP participants who are disabled must apply for SSI. See [0012.12 \(Applying for Other Benefits\)](#), [0030.03 \(Refugee Cash Assistance\)](#).

Refer applicants/participants who want help applying for or appealing SSI to a Social Security Advocate or the Disability Hub MN, 1-866-333-2466. See [0012.12.06 \(Special Services – Applying for Social Security\)](#).

Provide potentially eligible clients and clients who are referred to SSA with the [SSA web site](#) and toll-free telephone number. The toll-free number is 1-800-772-1213.

For information on Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA) resources, see the [Employment Services Manual](#) Appendix G (Resources for Americans with Disabilities (ADA)).